

that might otherwise be spread to the four winds. Nature doesn't like it. And she sends out agents of all sorts to try to eliminate it.

As mentioned often in this book, there are many of them, both inside and outside the family. Outside are tax collectors, lawyers, wealth managers, business advisers, investment analysts, luxury salesmen, and many others.

Inside are the vengeful spouses, neglected children, incompetent brothers-in-law, and spiteful siblings.

But the worst inside risk is the heir himself.

First, he might not be up to the challenge of managing wealth. Second, he may feel guilty about having it and be eager to get rid of it.

The desire for "fairness" seems to be innate in humans. The law of reciprocity decrees that when we give something, we should get something in return. So does the law of fairness tell us that if one person gets a good deal, the rest of us should get it, too.

But then, suppose you were born to a rich family, while many others were born to poor families. What are you to think of that? Where's the fairness in it? What can you do about it?

Most people are able to see through the thin veil of unfairness to the more profound truth behind it. We are all born with strengths and weaknesses. We take what we get. We make the best of it. That's fair.

Some are born tall, for example. Some are short. Studies show that tall people earn more money. Where's the fairness in that? Some are born good looking. Some aren't.

Studies show that good-looking people find it easier to get a job. One of the studies followed lawyers. It found that the more attractive the lawyer, the more rapidly his career developed. At the end of 15 years, he earned 13 percent more than his less attractive peers.¹ Where's the fairness in that?

Some people are born smart. Others are stupid. Again, studies show what you'd expect. Smart people, those who score highly on IQ tests, earn more money, are less likely to get divorced, live longer, and more rarely go to jail than stupid people.

One controversial book on the subject, *The Bell Curve*, by Richard Herrnstein and Charles Murray, argued that intelligence was more important than any other variable. The authors studied 12,000 young adults. They found that IQ predicted success much better than socioeconomic status. In